

Day One Essentials

The 30 phrases you'll use every single day in Sweden. Memorize these and you can handle 80% of basic interactions. This is your survival toolkit.

Greetings & Goodbyes

Swedes keep greetings simple. No hugs on first meeting, no kisses on cheeks (unless you know them well). A smile and a 'hej' is all you need. In fact, overdoing the greeting can make things awkward.

Hej!

/hey/

Hi! — Universal, works in every situation. The only greeting you truly need.

Hej hej!

/hey hey/

Hi hi! — Friendlier, more casual version. Very common.

God morgon

/goo MOR-on/

Good morning — Used until around noon.

God kväll

/goo kvell/

Good evening — From late afternoon onwards.

Hej då!

/hey DOH/

Goodbye! — The standard goodbye. Friendly and warm.

Vi ses!

/vee sess/

See you! — Casual, used with friends.

Ha det bra!

/hah deh brah/

Take care! — Literally 'have it good'. Very Swedish.

God natt

/goo naht/

Good night — Only when someone is actually going to sleep.

CULTURE TIP

Swedes almost never say 'god dag' (good day) in real life — it sounds extremely formal, almost old-fashioned. Stick with 'hej'. It works with your boss, your neighbor, the cashier, and the king. Yes, even the king.

The Magic Words

These seven words will carry you through almost any awkward situation. If you learn nothing else from this entire book, learn these.

Tack

/tahk/

Thanks — The single most important word in Swedish. Use it constantly.

Tack så mycket

/tahk soh MYH-keh/

Thank you so much — When regular 'tack' isn't enough.

Ja

/yah/

Yes — Short and simple. Sometimes Swedes inhale sharply while saying it.

Nej

/ney/

No — Rhymes with 'hey'.

Snälla

/SNEH-lah/

Please — Used when you're really asking nicely or begging a little.

Ursäkta

/ur-SHEK-tah/

Excuse me — To get someone's attention, or if you bump into someone.

Förlåt

/fur-LOHT/

Sorry — A real apology. Deeper than 'ursäkta'.

CULTURE TIP

Swedish doesn't use 'please' the way English does. You don't add 'snälla' to every sentence. Instead, adding 'tack' at the end of any request is the Swedish way of being polite. 'En kaffe, tack' = 'A coffee, please.' Simple, clean, Swedish.

CULTURE TIP

The Swedish inhaled 'ja' — you'll hear Swedes breathe IN while saying 'ja'. It sounds like a small gasp. It's completely normal and means enthusiastic agreement. Once you notice it, you'll hear it everywhere. Try it — instant Swedish vibes.

Useful Questions — Your Lifelines

When you're lost, confused, or just need help — these are the phrases that save you. Swedes are very helpful when asked directly.

Pratar du engelska?

/PRAH-tar doo ENG-el-ska/

Do you speak English? — Almost everyone does, but it's polite to ask first.

Vad betyder det?

/vah beh-TY-der deh/

What does that mean? — Your best friend when learning.

Kan du säga det igen?

/kan doo SAY-ah deh ee-YEN/

Can you say that again? — Don't be shy about asking.

Kan du prata långsammare?

/kan doo PRAH-tah LONG-sahm-ah-reh/

Can you speak more slowly? — Swedes talk fast. This helps.

Var är...?

/var air/

Where is...? — Fill in the blank. Toaletten? Stationen? Exit?

Hur mycket kostar det?

/hoor MY-keh KOS-tar deh/

How much does it cost? — Essential for shopping and eating out.

Vad heter du?

/vah HEH-ter doo/

What's your name? — Literally 'what are you called?'

Jag förstår inte

/yah fur-STOR IN-teh/

I don't understand — Honest and gets you help immediately.

Jag pratar lite svenska

/yah PRAH-tar LEE-teh SVEN-ska/

I speak a little Swedish — Sets expectations and earns respect.

CULTURE TIP

Start with 'Ursäkta, jag pratar lite svenska...' and then ask your question. This little introduction does two things: it tells the person to be patient with you, and it makes them genuinely happy that you're trying. Win-win.

Numbers 1–20

You'll need these for prices, addresses, times, ordering food, and understanding when the bus arrives. Get comfortable with 1-10 first, then build from there.

1 — Ett

/eht/

One — Note: 'en' is also used depending on the noun's gender.

2 — Två

/tvoh/

Two — The 'tv' combo is tricky. Practice it.

3 — Tre

/treh/

Three — Roll that R slightly.

4 — Fyra

/FYH-rah/

Four

5 — Fem

/fem/

Five — Easy one.

6 — Sex

/sex/

Six — Yes, it means six. Swedes don't giggle about it.

7 — Sju

/hwoo/

Seven — Uses that tricky SJ-sound from Chapter 1.

8 — Åtta

/OH-tah/

Eight — Remember, Å = 'oh'.

9 — Nio

/NEE-oh/

Nine — Two syllables.

10 — Tio

/TEE-oh/

Ten — Two syllables, just like nio.

11 — Elva | 12 — Tolv

/EL-vah/ | /tolv/

Eleven and twelve — Just memorize these.

13 — Tretton | 14 — Fjorton | 15 — Femton

/TREH-ton/ | /FYOR-ton/ | /FEM-ton/

Thirteen, fourteen, fifteen — Pattern: number + 'ton'.

16 — Sexton | 17 — Sjutton

/SEX-ton/ | /HWOO-ton/

Sixteen, seventeen.

18 — Arton | 19 — Nitton | 20 — Tjugo

/AR-ton/ | /NI-ton/ | /SHOO-goh/

Eighteen, nineteen, twenty. Note: Tjugo starts with a 'sh' sound!

CULTURE TIP

For prices, Swedes often say the number + 'kronor' (crowns). 'Det kostar femtio kronor' = 'It costs 50 kronor.' In casual speech they just say 'femtio spänn' — 'spänn' being slang for kronor, like 'bucks' in English.

Putting It All Together

Here's how a typical first interaction might sound. You walk into a shop, a café, or ask someone on the street:

Hej! Ursäkta, pratar du engelska?

/hey! ur-SHEK-tah, PRAH-tar doo ENG-el-ska/

Hi! Excuse me, do you speak English?

Jag pratar lite svenska. Var är tunnelbanan?

/yah PRAH-tar LEE-teh SVEN-ska. var air TUH-nel-BAH-nan/

I speak a little Swedish. Where is the metro?

Tack så mycket! Hej då!

/tahk soh MYH-keh! hey DOH/

Thank you so much! Goodbye!

CULTURE TIP

This simple three-line interaction — greeting, question, thank you — is the template for 90% of your conversations in Sweden. Master this flow and you'll navigate the entire country with confidence.

Listen to This Chapter

Scan the QR code to hear every phrase pronounced naturally. No robot voices — just real Swedish.

Next up: Chapter 03 — Fika & Food

Your complete guide to ordering, eating, and not embarrassing yourself at a Swedish table.